

Carol Bales

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UX RESEARCH LEADER

Results-driven UX Research Leader with a proven track record researching digital audiences for a major media company. Research manager experienced in building thriving and effective teams, Experience leading research from planning to analysis then translating results into actionable findings that support the product roadmap. Strategic leader hyper-focused on business strategies with a collaborative, people-focused management style. Thrives in dynamic environments where innovation and continuous learning drive exceptional user experiences.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Deliver high-quality, actionable user research
Plan research that answers critical business needs
Foster an informed user-first POV

Build and lead strong research teams
Support growth, retention, and monetization strategies
Translate data from multiple sources into clear insights

WORK EXPERIENCE

SILVER SPRING INTERACTIVE, Atlanta, GA

Jan 2025 – Present

Principal UX Strategist & Researcher

Providing user research and usability engineering for various clients on a consulting basis.

- Providing usability requirements and audience research for WABE 90.1 FM Digital Services to enhance customer satisfaction and increase retention as part of a broader shift to digital audiences.
- Principal strategist for a stealth startup helping seniors augment personal life and health management with ongoing assessment tools and gradually increasing scaffolding as abilities decline.

GEORGIA STATE UNIVERSITY, Atlanta, GA

Jan 2018 – present

Part-time Instructor, Dept of Computer Science

Teaching Intro to Human-Computer Interaction: Teams use human-centered research and design practices to prototype a solution to a real human problem then research their prototype. Preparing students for lifelong problem-solving using recent product design processes.

THE WEATHER COMPANY, IBM, Atlanta, GA

Oct 2018 – Aug 2023

Sr. Manager, Consumer Insights (Sr. User Researcher)

Led a high-volume, remote research team that expedited research to inform critical product decisions for an audience of 400 million across three brands and multiple platforms. Our team empowered B2C Product, Design, Editorial, Subscription, Advertising, Marketing, and Analytics teams with actionable primary research in a fast-paced, dynamic environment.

Delivering high-quality, actionable research that drove product decisions.

- Ran research on the connection between weather and well-being. Quantitative research found that 82% of the audience believes weather can impact their emotional and physical well-being. I then ran qualitative research to understand how, framing the findings for user stories. Results of these research iterations informed app redesign and a new marketing campaign.
- Discovered a 7% year-over-year drop in perceived app usability after I implemented quarterly UX metrics studies, quantifying the impact of over-use of ads. The finding served as a counterpoint to revenue numbers for the same period.
- Built and led a responsive research practice who delivered a multitude of research methodologies at a high cadence.
- Increased transparency and collaboration between stakeholders by launching a research repository and a monthly research showcase.
- Continuous advocacy for my team through coaching, mentoring, career guidance, standardization of methods, training and cross-training opportunities, and a flexible framework for parents during Covid.
- Used MaxDiff analysis to evaluate new editorial features; the winning candidate getting a 90% approval score. I then ran design evaluation on visual concepts for the top candidates. The final feature was released to subscriber audiences.

Supporting audience growth and retention strategies.

- Used findings from acquisition and churn research studies to write a customer journey map, embracing the fact that 60% of new users compare important weather forecasts between 2 or more weather apps and focusing on improving the first-time user experience.
- Assessed potential features and content and their effects on willingness-to-subscribe including categories of weather-related content, expert content, and custom alerts.
- Improved efficiency of bundled subscription purchase process by 37% using the RITE method of iterative evaluation.
- Measured a 26% rise in NPS score for a popular weather newsletter by performing quarterly metrics research.

Fostering a user-first POV within the organization through collaboration and communication with teams, stakeholders, and leadership.

- Brought the practice and language of UX best practices to product discussions and elevated the organization's capacity to deliver quality user experiences.

SILVER SPRING INTERACTIVE, Atlanta, GA

Feb 2011 – Sep 2018

UX Designer, Strategist and Researcher

In a consulting role for multiple large businesses in transportation, government, and CPG, I helped solve complex business and user problems. My wireframes served as canonical design requirements and focal points for stakeholder approval.

- Reduced call-wait and call-processing times for Delta Airlines' legacy call-center application. Prototyping and style recommendations.
- Improved user experience and business strategy for Y-combinator startup Exception-ALLY.
- Increased satisfaction and reduced attrition during the community selection and move-in process for Brookdale Senior Living.

FISERV, Atlanta, GA

May 2009 – Jan 2011

Sr. UX Architect (& Researcher)

Working closely with product management, business analysts and development, I designed new features for bill-pay users and internal call-center representatives accounting for Fiserv's complex financial systems. I then prototyped and tested enhancements with our target audiences.

- Improved findability of key information by 70% in Fiserv's bill-pay call center application.
- Increased search efficiency in Fiserv's biller search API for Walmart Money Centers.

CARTOON NETWORK, Atlanta, GA

July 2008 – Jan 2009

UX Architect

As part of the FusionFall team, I worked closely with product management and game designers to prototype and document UX design features both online and in-game.

- Created efficient Web account sign-up and account management
- Improved usability for in-game heads-up-display for MMOG FusionFall

INTERCONTINENTAL HOTELS GROUP, Atlanta, GA

Mar 2004 – Sep 2005

UX Architect

Extensive wireframing and prototyping refinement of hotel reservation process. I also worked with external vendors to conduct usability testing, and internal development conducting complex A/B split-testing to refine reservation completion rates. The content management system included multiple brands, languages and country sites.

- Improved efficiency on hotel search results, hotel reservation process, and hotel detail pages resulting in significant revenue increases across international sites.

IBM INTERACTIVE DESIGN STUDIOS, Atlanta, GA

Mar 1999 – July 2003

Sr. Information Architect

As part of this consultancy, I worked with multiple proposal and fulfillment teams, creating design documentation for enterprise systems. We performed extensive strategic business consulting to address shifts in business process, technological frameworks, as well as novel experiences.

- Information Architecture for Finance, Transportation, Publishing, Entertainment, Consulting, and Government Apps
- Heuristic Evaluations, Process Assessment, Content Strategy, and Information Visualization

EDUCATION

Master of Computer Science, Human-Computer Interaction

Georgia Institute of Technology, Atlanta, GA

Bachelor of Arts, Fine Arts

University of Tennessee, Knoxville, TN

SKILLS & TOOLS

Skills: User Research, Heuristic Evaluation, Usability, Qualitative/Quantitative, Research Design, Remote-moderated or unmoderated, Mixed methods, Formative & Summative, Research-based Requirements-writing, Moderation, SUS, NPS, CSAT, RITE Method, Surveys, Third-party data, Usage metrics, UX Strategy, UX Design, UI Design, Design Thinking, Interaction Design, Prototyping, Journey Mapping, People Manager, Practice Building, Team Leader, Mentoring & Coaching, Innovation, Budget & Planning, Teaching, Vendor Management, Stakeholder Relations, Excellent Communications & Storytelling, GenAI for Research, Emerging Tech

Industries: Media, Financial, Transportation, Hospitality, Government, Entertainment, Gaming, eCommerce, Telecomm, SaaS, InfoTech, Privacy Compliance

Tools: Alchemer, UserZoom, SPSS, Mural, UserTesting, Qualtrics, Morai, OvoStudios, Figma, Mural, InDesign, Axure, Adobe XD, Adobe Photoshop, ChatGPT, Gemini, Midjourney, Trello, Slack, Jira, Salesforce, OneTrust, Discourse, Generative AI, Google Analytics, Looker